

Overview

Youth Economy Lab: Student Scholars Research Competition

Official Competition Guide & Participant Handbook - In Partnership with Synthica Research Group

1. Introduction

The **Youth Economy Lab (YEL) Student Scholars Research Competition** is a global academic research competition designed to encourage high school students to explore complex issues in **economics and finance through structured research proposals**.

In partnership with **Synthica Research Group**, the competition aims to provide a platform for students to develop **rigorous academic ideas and transform them into real research projects**.

Participants will design a **high-quality research proposal** that outlines a compelling research question, relevant academic context, and a feasible methodology for investigating a real economic or financial issue.

Unlike traditional essay competitions, the Student Scholars Research Competition emphasises **academic research design**, requiring participants to think like scholars and develop proposals aligned with the standards used in university-level research.

The competition also serves as a **pipeline into advanced research opportunities**, with the top finalists gaining access to Synthica's research ecosystem and mentorship from scholars connected with leading global universities.

2. About Youth Economy Lab

Youth Economy Lab (YEL) is a global student-led economics initiative focused on expanding access to economic education, research opportunities, and financial literacy initiatives.

YEL operates several academic initiatives including:

- Global economics competitions with social impact
- Research proposal challenges
- Guest speaker programs featuring finance professionals and academics
- Student publications and economic essays

The organization currently has:

- **550+ active global members**
- **250,000+ organic impressions across digital platforms**
- recognition through the **IB Global Youth Action Fund 2026**, where YEL received a **\$2,500 grant** for expanding youth economic education initiatives.

YEL aims to bridge the gap between **academic economic theory and real-world research opportunities** for high school students.

3. About Synthica Research Group

Synthica Research Group is a global student-led research initiative dedicated to making academic research opportunities more accessible for high school students worldwide.

Many existing research programs are either highly selective or extremely expensive. Synthica was created to address this challenge by providing:

- accessible research opportunities
- collaborative academic environments
- mentorship from scholars connected to leading universities

The **Synthica Research Program** is highly competitive, typically receiving **over 1,000 applications each cycle**, with an acceptance rate of approximately **1.5–2%**.

Students admitted to Synthica cohorts have the opportunity to collaborate with researchers and mentors connected to institutions such as:

- Stanford University
- Harvard University
- Massachusetts Institute of Technology
- Georgia Institute of Technology
- University of Pennsylvania
- Duke University

Website:

<https://www.synthica.org/>

4. Competition Overview

The **Student Scholars Research Competition** invites students to submit **an original research proposal in the fields of economics or finance**.

The competition focuses on **proposal design and pitch rather than full research execution**.

Participants will develop a proposal containing:

- a clearly defined research question
- a discussion of relevant literature or economic context
- a proposed methodology for analysis
- the expected significance of the research

The objective is to demonstrate **academic thinking, analytical reasoning, methodological design** and ability to **think on the spot**.

Competitors will be evaluated by an expert panel based on research quality, originality, feasibility, and clarity.

Research competitions often assess proposals based on criteria such as **originality of the research question, methodological rigour, and clarity of writing**, which are widely used standards in academic competitions.

5. Competition Structure

Stage 1 – Research Proposal Submission

Participants submit their **written research proposal**.

The proposal must clearly articulate:

- the research question
- background context
- theoretical framework
- proposed research methodology
- expected findings or implications

Submissions will be reviewed by the judging panel.

Stage 2 – Academic Evaluation

Proposals will be evaluated using a structured rubric focusing on:

- research significance
- originality
- feasibility
- methodological rigour

Judges will independently review submissions and assign scores based on these criteria.

Scores from multiple judges will be averaged to determine final rankings. Selecting Top 20 Research proposals

Stage 4 - Research Seminar

Top 20 qualifiers will then participate in a research seminar in which they will pitch their proposal and methodology to a panel of judges and Synthica Professors.

Who will then select the Top 5 as winners

Stage 3 – Final Selection

The **Top 5 proposals** will be selected as winners of the competition.

These students will receive admission into the **Synthica Research Cohort** and access to additional research opportunities.

6. Competition Benefits

The **Top 5 Winners** will receive the following academic opportunities.

a. Guaranteed Admission to Synthica Research Cohort

The top 5 students will receive **confirmed acceptance into the Synthica Research Cohort**.

The Synthica Research Program typically has an acceptance rate of **approximately 2%**, making this an exclusive academic opportunity.

Within the program, participants will:

- collaborate with fellow student researchers
- work closely with professors and mentors
- develop their proposal into a full academic research paper

b. Academic Publication Pathway

Students will receive guidance to transform their proposal into a **complete research paper suitable for submission to indexed academic journals**.

Mentorship will support:

- literature review development
- econometric or statistical analysis
- academic writing and formatting
- peer review preparation

c. Participation in the Global Research Challenge

Finalists will also be invited to participate in the **Synthica Global Research Challenge**, where they will:

- receive mentorship from research mentors
- further develop their proposal
- conduct real research analysis

Students can use their **competition proposal as the foundation for the research project**.

d. Program Fee Waiver

Finalists will receive a **waiver of the \$30 joining fee** for the Global Research Challenge.

e. Official Recognition

All finalists will receive:

- signed certificates from **Youth Economy Lab and Synthica Research Group**
- official recognition across YEL platforms
- the ability to showcase the achievement in **university applications and research portfolios**

Submission Guidelines

7. Eligible Research Topics

All submissions must be **economics or finance centered**.
Students may explore topics across multiple research fields.

Examples include:

Financial Markets

- stock market prediction models
- algorithmic trading
- volatility modelling
- market efficiency analysis

Macroeconomics

- inflation dynamics
- monetary policy impacts
- economic growth models
- global trade and supply chains

Financial Technology

- artificial intelligence in financial markets
- blockchain systems
- digital payments and banking adoption

Development Economics

- financial inclusion
- microfinance institutions
- access to credit in developing economies

Behavioral Finance

- investor psychology
- retail trading behavior
- risk perception in financial markets

8. Submission Requirements

Participants must submit a **single PDF document containing the following sections**.

Cover Page

Required information:

- full name (as registered)
- title of research proposal
- registered email address
- city, country

Research Proposal

Length: **1 - 2 pages maximum**

The proposal should contain:

- **Introduction**
Brief explanation of the economic problem being studied.
- **Research Question**
Clearly defined and focused question guiding the study.
- **Literature Context**
Overview of existing research or economic theories related to the topic.
- **Proposed Methodology**
Explanation of how the research will be conducted.
Possible methods include:
 - econometric modelling
 - financial data analysis
 - statistical modelling
 - case study analysis
 - machine learning methods
- **Expected Contribution**
Explanation of the potential impact of the research.

References

A separate references section must be included.

References **do not count toward the proposal page limit.**

9. Citation Requirements

All sources must be properly cited.

Accepted citation formats:

- **APA 7th Edition**
- **MLA**

References must be listed **alphabetically by the author's last name**.

10. Formatting Requirements

All submissions must follow the formatting guidelines below.

- Font: **Times New Roman**
- Font Size: **12**
- Margins: **1 inch (2.5 cm)**
- Spacing: **Single spaced**

File Format:

PDF (Adobe Acrobat)

Submissions that do not meet these formatting standards may be disqualified.

12. Academic Integrity Policy

- Participants must ensure that their work is **entirely original**.
- All submissions will undergo plagiarism detection.
- Academic competitions emphasise strict plagiarism policies and proper citation of prior work to ensure research credibility.
- Any plagiarism will result in **immediate disqualification**.

13. Submission Deadline

All proposals must be submitted **before the official deadline**.

Late submissions will **not be accepted**.

14. Competition Timeline

Registration Opens: TBA

Submission Deadline: TBA

Finalists Announced: TBA

Synthica Research Cohort Begins: TBA

Judging Criteria

Judging & Evaluation Framework

All submissions to the **Youth Economy Lab Student Scholars Research Competition** will be evaluated using a structured academic research rubric. The judging framework is designed to assess both the **intellectual merit and practical feasibility** of the proposed research.

Each submission will be reviewed independently by members of the judging panel, and scores will be assigned across five evaluation categories.

Research Proposal Judging Rubric

Evaluation Category	Evaluation Question	What Judges Look For	Maximum Score
Research Problem & Significance	What is the background of the problem? Is the need for research clearly identified?	Clear explanation of the economic or financial issue being studied. Demonstrates understanding of why the research is important and relevant. Identifies a meaningful research gap or unanswered question.	20
Existing Literature & Context	How well does the proposal engage with existing research or economic theory?	Demonstrates awareness of previous research, economic theories, or relevant financial studies. Shows how the proposed research builds upon or contributes to existing knowledge. Sources are credible and relevant.	20
Research Design & Methodology	Is the proposed research method appropriate and feasible for answering the research question?	Clear explanation of how the research will be conducted. Methodology aligns logically with the research question. Demonstrates understanding of analytical tools such as econometric models, financial data analysis, statistical methods, case studies, or machine learning techniques.	25

Originality & Innovation	Does the proposal introduce a novel idea, approach, or perspective?	Research question demonstrates creativity and intellectual curiosity. Proposal offers a new insight, approach, or application in economics or finance. Judges will reward projects that explore emerging areas such as fintech, behavioral finance, or AI in financial markets.	20
Clarity, Structure & Academic Writing	Is the proposal clearly written and logically structured?	Proposal is well-organized and easy to follow. Arguments are presented logically and concisely. Writing demonstrates strong academic tone and professionalism. Proper citations and formatting are used.	15

Total Score

Total Possible Points: 100

Additional Evaluation Notes

Judges will also consider the following qualitative factors when evaluating proposals:

- Feasibility of the research project if developed into a full paper
- Strength of the proposed analytical framework
- Potential contribution to economic or financial understanding
- Relevance to real-world economic challenges

Proposals that demonstrate **clear intellectual curiosity, strong analytical thinking, and rigorous research design** will score highest.

Tie-Breaking Policy

If two or more submissions receive identical scores, judges may evaluate proposals based on:

1. Strength of the **research question**
2. Feasibility of the **proposed methodology**
3. Overall **intellectual contribution of the research idea**